

Sample family letter, adapt before sending home

Dear families of our Grade 6 class,

Next week our class will read a passage from *Tenuous Threads* by Judy Abrams. Judy was born in Hungary in 1937, was hidden in a convent in Budapest as a small child during the Holocaust, and lives in Canada today. Her memoir was published in 2011 by the Azrieli Foundation's Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program, and the Foundation provides free copies of the book to Canadian schools. Holocaust education is part of the Ontario Grade 6 Social Studies curriculum, added in the 2023 revision under expectations A3.7 and B3.5. I am writing to let you know what is coming and how I am teaching it, because this is the kind of lesson that benefits from a parent knowing it is on the way.

Here is what I am asking of your child. There is no assigned reading at home before class. The first reading of Judy's words happens together, in the room, with me. After class, your child will have a written reflection due 24 hours later. The reflection is a 6 to 12 sentence response to a prompt they choose from three options. The 24-hour gap is on purpose. It comes from the Azrieli Foundation's own trauma-informed teaching guidance: students sit with a difficult reading overnight rather than rushing a response while their feelings are still loud. The work is better and the night is kinder when there is space between the reading and the writing.

Here is what I am asking of you. Talk to your child about the lesson if they want to talk. Do not push. Do not avoid. They might come home full of questions. They might come home quiet. Both are normal. If your family has lived experience of the Holocaust, or of another genocide, or of religious or ethnic persecution, you decide whether and how to share any of that with your child. The lesson does not require any student to disclose anything about their family. It also does not single out Jewish students or any other students to speak for their community. Your child's job in class is to read what Judy wrote and to think carefully about it. That is everyone's job.

If your child needs support during or after the lesson, here is what is available to them. Inside the school they can talk to me, to the school counsellor, or to a trusted educational assistant. If something comes up at home outside of school hours, the Kids Help Phone is open 24 hours a day at 1-800-668-6868, and it is free and confidential. You are also welcome to email me directly at any time. I will read what you send and I will get back to you, even if it takes a day. I would rather hear from you than not.

Sincerely,

Your child's teacher

Teachers using this lesson, add your name, school, room number, and email above before sending this letter home. The body of the letter has been written to be adaptable to any classroom using Tenuous Threads.

Tenuous Threads is published by The Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program. Free copies for Canadian educators at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/memoirs/.